

USC - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG TEN

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-15 caliber with a playoff ceiling driven by a proven offense; the defense is talented enough to improve but carries new-coordinator and replacement volatility.
Preseason consensus	AP No. 14 (839 points) · SP+ No. 12
Returning production	64% (No. 16) overall · Off. 64% (No. 26) · Def. 64% (No. 20)
Primer power rating	+17.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	7.8 wins · likely 8-4
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar overall, with offensive continuity offset by receiver/TE turnover and a defense transitioning to Gary Patterson.
Confidence	Medium-high

2026 identity: USC should again win through Lincoln Riley and QB Jayden Maiava: an efficient, explosive passing offense with a deep two-back component and enough OL continuity to stay high-end despite the center injury. Gary Patterson's multiple 4-2-5 gives the defense a new organizing idea.

Bottom line: USC has a playoff-quality offense and a top-15 overall profile, but the ceiling depends on Patterson producing a more consistent defense while the OL absorbs Kilian O'Connor's season-ending loss against a top-15 schedule.

Beats expectations if: QB Jayden Maiava sustains the 2025 efficiency/explosiveness, RB Waymond Jordan and RB King Miller make the offense less one-dimensional, the four healthy returning OL pieces settle around a functional new center, and Patterson converts experienced transfers/returners into a defense that wins more early downs.

Disappoints if: The receiver/TE turnover lowers the passing-game ceiling, center instability creates protection leakage, and the new defense continues allowing too many successful and explosive plays against Oregon/Ohio State/Indiana-level offenses.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB stability:** QB Jayden Maiava is the established quarterback after 3,711 passing yards and 24 TDs in 13 starts, giving USC rare third-year continuity with Riley/Huard.
- 2 2025 baseline:** The 2025 offense was genuinely elite: No. 8 total offense, No. 7 EPA/play, No. 12 success rate and No. 8 explosive-play rate.
- 3 ? OL questions:** C Kilian O'Connor is out for the season, breaking what had been five-man OL continuity; the exact center solution remains open.
- 4 Coaching:** Gary Patterson is the new DC and he is the defensive play-caller; his multiple 4-2-5 is the biggest structural change on the team.
- 5 Schedule pressure:** USC faces a 9/10 schedule (SP+ SOS No. 11) with Oregon, Penn State, Ohio State and Indiana all on the slate.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	9-4 (7-2 Big Ten)	● Good
Scoring	35.8 PPG	● Elite
Total offense	465.5 YPG	● Elite
Rush offense	169.5 YPG · 5.1 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass efficiency	9.16 YPA · 26 TD / 10 INT	● Elite
Third downs	51.3%	● Elite
Scoring defense	23.0 PPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Total defense	350.8 YPG allowed	● Good / above average
Rush defense	143.2 YPG · 4.4 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass defense	207.5 YPG · 6.85 YPA · 22 TD allowed	● Average / mixed

USC was an offense-first contender: scoring offense ranked No. 13, total offense No. 8, pass efficiency No. 11 and third downs No. 5. The defense was closer to average, with scoring defense No. 51, total defense No. 49 and pass-efficiency defense No. 81.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+8.24 · No. 12	● Elite
Off. EPA/play	+0.239 · No. 7	● Elite
Off. success rate	49.3% · No. 12	● Elite
Off. explosive-play rate	15.6% · No. 8	● Elite
Havoc allowed	13.4% · No. 38	● Good / above average
Opp.-adjusted defense	+4.55 · No. 26	● Very good
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.081 · No. 34	● Very good
Def. success rate allowed	44.1% · No. 101	● Below average
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	12.9% · No. 92	● Below average
Havoc created	15.5% · No. 70	● Average / mixed

Advanced-stat read: USC's offensive reputation is fully supported by the data: elite EPA, success rate, explosiveness, total offense and third-down performance. The defense is more nuanced than a simple “bad defense” label-opponent-adjusted rating and EPA/play allowed were very good, but success rate allowed (No. 101) and explosive-play prevention (No. 92) were weak.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC / offensive play-caller	Lincoln Riley - Returning HC; offensive play-calling	● ↔ Lincoln Riley retains primary offensive play-calling authority, keeping the top-level offensive structure stable.
OC	Luke Huard - Returning OC/QB; Dennis Simmons adds co-OC title	● ↔ Luke Huard returns at OC/QB while Dennis Simmons' co-OC title adds responsibility without changing Riley's primary calling role.
DC / defensive play-caller	◆ Gary Patterson - New external DC; defensive play-caller	● ↑ Defensive play-calling responsibility is settled within the staff

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ WR Terrell Anderson	NC State	● ↔ 39-629-5 in 2025 and projects with the first receiving group; important replacement production.
◆ TE Tucker Ashcraft	Wisconsin	● ↔ Adds major-rotation competition in a TE room replacing TE Walker Lyons/TE Lake McRee.

Out	To	Loss
WR Makai Lemon	NFL (Philadelphia), Round 1, No. 20	● ↓ 2025 first-team All-Big Ten caliber receiver departure removes proven top-line production.
WR Ja’Kobi Lane	NFL (Baltimore), Round 3, No. 80	● ↓ Another established receiver leaves, forcing WR Tanook Hines, WR Terrell Anderson and WR Zacharyus Williams to absorb larger roles.
TE Walker Lyons	BYU	● ↓ 2025 All-Big Ten honorable-mention TE transfer is a composition-significant loss.
TE Lake McRee	NFL (Pittsburgh), undrafted free agent	● ↓ The 2025 second-team All-Big Ten TE departs for the NFL, compounding the TE reset.

Offensive net: ● ↔ high-end offense with more pass-catcher turnover than the returning-production number alone suggests. QB/RB/most OL continuity keeps the floor high; WR/TE roles must be redistributed.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ CB Jontez Williams	Iowa State	● ↑ 29 career starts, Bednarik recognition and full-go camp status give USC a proven corner anchor.
◆ DT Alex VanSumeren	Michigan State	● ↑ 52 tackles in 2025 and projects first at nose tackle, directly reinforcing the front.
◆ LB Deven Bryant	Washington	● ↑ 62 tackles/10 starts and a projected first-unit role supply experienced linebacker production.

Out	To	Loss
DL Devan Thompkins	Alabama	● ↓ 2025 All-Big Ten honorable-mention DT leaves during a scheme transition.
LB Eric Gentry	NFL (Cincinnati), undrafted free agent	● ↓ The experienced linebacker departs for the NFL.
DE Anthony Lucas	NFL (Detroit), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Material edge contributor departs, adding to front turnover.
S Kamari Ramsey / S Bishop Fitzgerald	Kamari Ramsey: NFL (Houston), Round 5, No. 141; Bishop Fitzgerald: Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ Two material 2025 secondary contributors leave; replacement chemistry is part of Patterson's transition.

Defensive net: ● ↑ modest scheme/talent upside but medium stability. Patterson plus CB Jontez Williams/DT Alex VanSumeren/LB Deven Bryant can improve the structure, while multiple 2025 starters/contributors still have to be replaced.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Lincoln Riley offense with QB Jayden Maiava entering a third year in-system, built around efficient/explosive passing and a legitimate RB Waymond Jordan/RB King Miller two-back threat.	Quarterback continuity, elite 2025 EPA/success/explosiveness and enough OL continuity to support the system.	Replacing WR Makai Lemon/WR Ja'Kobi Lane/TE Walker Lyons/TE Lake McRee and solving center after O'Connor's season-ending injury.
Defense	Gary Patterson multiple 4-2-5 with flexible man/zone distribution and an evolving blend of useful 2025 concepts.	Experienced transfer additions at DT/LB/CB and a 2025 unit that was No. 26 opponent-adjusted and No. 34 by EPA/play allowed.	The 2025 defense allowed too many successful and explosive plays, and the new system must replace several professional/transfer departures.
Special teams	Strong returning kicker with turnover elsewhere in the operation.	K Ryon Sayeri went 21-of-25 and has Groza recognition.	Punter/LS turnover and the special-teams model signal at No. 100.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● A–	● ↔	High	QB Jayden Maiava brings 3,711 yards, 24 TDs and deep system continuity
RB	● A–	● ↑	High	RB Waymond Jordan returns to pair with RB King Miller in a deep backfield
WR	● B+	● ↓	Medium	WR Terrell Anderson joins a talented room replacing WR Makai Lemon and WR Ja'Kobi Lane
TE	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	TE Tucker Ashcraft helps replace TE Walker Lyons and TE Lake McRee
OL	● B+	● ↔	Medium	OL Alani Noa anchors a veteran group adjusting to C Kilian O'Connor's injury
DL/Edge	● B	● ↔	Medium	DT Alex VanSumeren adds proven interior experience to a changing front
LB	● B	● ↔	Medium	LB Deven Bryant adds starting experience after LB Eric Gentry's departure
Secondary	● B	● ↔	Medium	CB Jontez Williams brings 29 career starts to Patterson's secondary rebuild
Special teams	● C+	● ↓	Medium	K Ryon Sayeri stabilizes a unit replacing other specialist pieces
Coaching	● A–	● ↑	Medium-high	Accepted staff changes add upside without altering the underlying team baseline
Overall	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	Top-15 caliber with a playoff ceiling, driven by a proven offense and a talented but volatile rebuilt defense.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through August 24, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
★ Jayden Maiava	QB	● High-end national starter	Big Ten preseason honoree · Maxwell · Walter Camp POY	3,711 yards/24 TDs and system continuity make him the engine of USC's top-10-caliber offense.
Waymond Jordan	RB	● High-upside conference star	Maxwell	Returns healthy after 576 yards in only six 2025 games and pairs with King Miller to give USC real backfield depth.
King Miller	RB	● High-end conference starter	-	972 rushing yards in 2025 give USC proven production if Jordan's workload is managed.
Jontez Williams	CB	● High-end conference starter / impact transfer	Bednarik	29 career starts and full-go fall status make him the most proven piece of Patterson's secondary rebuild.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Alani Noa	OL	● High-end conference guard	Outland	Returning RG and watchlist player becomes even more important after the center injury disrupted OL continuity.
Alex VanSumeren	DT	● Solid-to-high-end Power 4 starter projection	-	52 tackles at Michigan State and a projected first-unit nose role give Patterson immediate interior experience.
Deven Bryant	LB	● Solid Power 4 starter projection	-	62 tackles and 10 starts at Washington supply needed first-unit experience after Eric Gentry's departure.
Ryon Sayeri	K	● High-end specialist	Lou Groza	21-of-25 in 2025 and a school single-season record make kicker a stabilizing piece of an otherwise shaky special-teams projection.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Top-15 difficulty with several elite-opponent spikes; the early nonconference runway helps, but USC must survive multiple playoff-caliber Big Ten offenses.
Difficulty	● 9/10 · SP+ SOS No. 11
Hardest stretch	Oregon → Washington → at Penn State. Three consecutive SP+ top-20 opponents (No. 2, 18, 17) before the first open date.
Swing games	at Penn State, Washington
Advantage	USC opens with three home games against non-project FBS opponents before Big Ten play, giving the reconfigured OL and new defense a runway before Oregon.
Expected	7.8 wins · likely 8-4
Floor / ceiling	6-6 / 10-2

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	USC should attract offense-driven optimism because QB Jayden Maiava/Riley return and the team is AP No. 14. The main risk is paying for assumed defensive improvement before Patterson's first unit proves it can suppress success and explosives.
Back them when	The center configuration is stable and USC faces a defense vulnerable to efficient passing/explosive plays; also attractive when the two-back run threat can keep opponents from selling out on QB Jayden Maiava.
Fade/pass when	The opponent can stress the new center/front with pressure or owns an elite offense capable of attacking USC's 2025 success/explosive-prevention weakness before the Patterson transition is proven.
Key monitor	post-O'Connor center configuration, Patterson defensive installation/first-unit roles, CB Jontez Williams and other CB health, receiver hierarchy after WR Makai Lemon/WR Ja'Kobi Lane, punter/long-snap operation, live market, injuries and weather later market check
Week 1 baseline	USC -35.0 vs. San Jose State · early rating-based fair value; compare with the live market before betting. Live market: USC -38.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

USC has a playoff-caliber offensive foundation around QB Jayden Maiava, an experienced backfield and Lincoln Riley's system. The main uncertainty is whether the reconfigured center spot and rebuilt pass-catcher hierarchy can stay efficient while Gary Patterson lifts the defense.

An 8-4 baseline reflects both the top-15 talent level and a brutal schedule. USC deserves respect, but preseason prices should leave room for proof that the new defensive structure and OL configuration are ready for elite Big Ten opponents.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [spring outlook](#) · [center update](#) · [CB watchlist](#) · [secondary injuries](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [DC Patterson](#) · [coaching staff](#)

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